

**BEFORE THE STATE BOARD OF LICENSED PROFESSIONAL COUNSELOR
EXAMINERS**

STATE OF COLORADO

Case Nos. 2015-2471 and 2016-626

STIPULATION AND FINAL BOARD ORDER

**IN THE MATTER OF DISCIPLINARY PROCEEDINGS REGARDING THE
LICENSE TO PRACTICE PROFESSIONAL COUNSELING IN THE STATE OF
COLORADO OF STEVEN J. WOLHANDLER, LICENSE NO. LPC 4564,**

Respondent.

**IT IS HEREBY STIPULATED by and between the State Board of Licensed
Professional Counselor Examiners and (the "Board") and Steven J. Wolhandler
("Respondent") as follows:**

- 1. Respondent is a licensed professional counselor ("LPC"), license
number LPC 4564, within the State of Colorado.**
- 2. The Board has jurisdiction over Respondent and the subject matter of
this Stipulation and Final Board Order ("Order") pursuant to the provisions of the
Mental Health Practice Act, § 12-43-101 *et seq.*, C.R.S. ("MHPA").**
- 3. It is the intent of the parties and the purpose of this Order to provide
for a settlement of all matters arising out of case numbers 2015-2471 and 2016-626
without the necessity of holding a formal hearing.**
- 4. This Order is a full and final resolution of case numbers 2015-2471 and
2016-626. This Order does not resolve any other cases, complaints, or matters,
known or unknown to the Board or Respondent, as of the effective date of this
Order.**
- 5. Respondent admits the following:**
 - a. Respondent had a nine (9) year therapeutic relationship with
J.N., which included couples counseling with J.N. and her
husband, B.R., and individual counseling with J.N.**

- b. Prior to working with J.N., Respondent provided individual counseling to B.R.
- c. Respondent engaged in a dual relationship with J.N. by providing therapy and subsequently providing consulting services to J.N. regarding parental responsibility recommendations that involved B.R.
- d. On or around January 2014, Respondent met J.N. at a police station. The following morning, Respondent met J.N. at court and watched a hearing with J.N. when she requested an order of protection against B.R.
- e. Respondent and J.N. engaged in numerous phone calls and texts, many after hours, including at 4:00 a.m.
- f. Although J.N. previously introduced Respondent to her mother as J.N.'s therapist, Respondent contacted J.N.'s mother without a signed release of information from J.N.
- g. Respondent did not clearly delineate between the billing for therapy and consulting services.
- h. Respondent's records failed to contain a signed mandatory disclosure form, intake documents, progress notes, treatment plans, diagnoses, or billing invoices/statements.

6. By virtue of the facts admitted in paragraph 5 above, the Board finds that Respondent violated §§ 12-43-214(1), 12-43-218(1), 12-43-222(1)(b), (g)(I), (i), (p), and (u), C.R.S.

PROBATION

7. Respondent's license to practice as an LPC in the State of Colorado is hereby placed on probation for four (4) years commencing from the effective date of this Order. During the probationary period, Respondent shall be bound by the terms and restrictions set forth in this Order.

8. The period of probation is tolled during any time that Respondent is not practicing as an LPC in the State of Colorado, and such period of probation shall resume at such time as Respondent resumes practicing as an LPC in the State of Colorado in accordance with this Order.

9. Credit toward the period of probation will be given only for the period of time during which Respondent is practicing as an LPC in the State of Colorado and is in full compliance with this Order.

10. If, after two (2) years of the probationary period, Respondent has adhered to all terms and conditions of this Order, Respondent may request that the Board consider termination of the probation. Request for termination of probation must be made in writing to the Board, and Respondent is responsible for establishing, to the satisfaction of the Board, that he has satisfied all terms and conditions of probation.

PRACTICE MONITOR

11. During the term of probation, Respondent's practice shall be monitored by a practice monitor. Within 30 days of the effective date of this Order, Respondent shall submit, in writing, three (3) proposed practice monitors for the Board's approval. If this requirement is not satisfied, Respondent must cease practice and agrees to suspension of his practice until he submits three (3) proposed practice monitors. Respondent shall include a program-approved practice monitor application from each potential monitor, with attached curriculum vita or resume. The practice monitor shall meet the following criteria:

- a. The practice monitor shall be a licensed, certified, or listed, currently practicing mental health provider in the State of Colorado;
- b. It is recommended that the practice monitor have a minimum of five (5) years of experience and has not been subject to professional discipline; and,
- c. The practice monitor shall have no current or past financial or personal interest in Respondent or Respondent's practice. Former employees and business associates fall under this provision.

12. After the Board's written approval of the practice monitor, Respondent and the practice monitor shall enter into a written contract for monitoring within thirty (30) days. If this requirement is not satisfied, Respondent must cease practice and agrees to suspension of his practice until the written contract for practice monitoring is executed. The practice monitor shall provide a copy of the written contract to the Board as a part of his/her first report to the Board. The contract must contain a provision stating that the practice monitor has received a copy of this Order, the complaint and responsive documents, any investigative report, and any prior practice evaluation; has read these documents; and

understands the duties and responsibilities s/he is undertaking as Respondent's practice monitor. The practice monitor shall ensure that a written notification is provided to each of Respondent's clients, informing the clients of the name, address, and telephone number of the practice monitor. This written notification may be provided in a mandatory disclosure statement.

13. The practice monitor shall conduct a practice evaluation during the first month of practice monitoring. The practice evaluation shall examine all aspects of Respondent's practice or proposed practice and his qualifications and ability to practice in accordance with generally accepted standards of practice and with skill and safety for clients, and determine whether he has the necessary qualifications, current ability, and competence to practice. The first practice monitoring report shall include the findings of the practice evaluation.

14. Should the Board determine from the practice monitor's evaluation that Respondent cannot practice any part of his practice with skill and safety for clients in accordance with generally accepted standards of practice or does not have the appropriate qualifications, ability or competence for practice, Respondent shall immediately cease any part of the practice that the Board determines, based on the evaluation, he is not qualified, competent, or safe to conduct. Based on the Board's findings and the evaluation, the Board will determine necessary actions that Respondent must take and conditions Respondent must meet so that Respondent can practice with skill and safety for clients in accordance with generally accepted standards of practice in any areas the Board finds Respondent is not qualified, competent, and safe to practice. Once Respondent satisfies the Board that he is qualified, competent, and safe to fully practice, Respondent may resume full practice.

15. The practice monitoring shall consist of individual, in-person (face-to-face) sessions that occur for one (1) hour, or such longer time as the practice monitor deems necessary, for every twenty (20) hours of client contact, but at least once each month. Respondent and his practice monitor must review and discuss each of Respondent's active cases at least once every month for the first 12 months in order to allow the practice monitor to be able to determine whether Respondent is practicing professional counseling in accordance with generally accepted standards of practice and with skill and safety for his clients. After the first 12 months, the practice monitor has discretion to alter the frequency of individual, in-person (face-to-face) sessions with Respondent, but said sessions may not occur less than once each quarter.

16. The practice monitor shall submit a written report to the Board on the fifth day of the month following the first full month of practice monitoring. All subsequent reports shall be submitted on the fifth day of each month for the first twelve (12) reports. After the submission of the first twelve (12) reports the practice

monitor shall submit his/her reports by the fifth day of every third month (i.e. on a quarterly basis) until the practice monitoring is completed.

17. If at any time the Board has questions or concerns regarding the monitoring, the practice monitor agrees to attend any Board meeting necessary to address the Board's concerns. The Board will give the practice monitor 30 days of notice prior to requiring the practice monitor's attendance at the Board meeting.

18. If at any time the practice monitor believes Respondent is not in compliance with this Order, is unable to practice with skill and safety to his clients, or has committed a violation of the practice act or rules and regulations, the practice monitor shall immediately notify the Board, in writing, and include the basis for this conclusion. A copy will be sent to Respondent. Upon submission of such a report, Respondent shall immediately cease the practice of professional counseling.

19. Respondent shall make every effort to ensure that all reports by the practice monitor are complete and timely submitted to the Board. If, in the Board's judgment, the practice monitor fails to perform the function specified by this Order, the Board may require that a new practice monitor assume the responsibilities herein. If for any reason the practice monitor ceases to perform the functions specified in this Order, Respondent shall submit, in writing, a new proposed practice monitor to the Board within 30 days.

20. Respondent or the practice monitor may terminate the monitoring relationship upon written notice to the other and to the Board not less than 60 days before the date of termination. The notice shall state the reason for the termination. Respondent shall immediately initiate efforts to obtain another Board-approved practice monitor, who shall conduct her/his monitoring and report to the Board in accordance with this Order.

CONTINUING EDUCATION

21. During the term of probation, Respondent shall successfully complete the ProBE – Professional/Problem Based Ethics program (www.cpepd.org). To successfully complete the program, Respondent must receive a passing evaluation or grade, without any condition or qualification. Upon completion of the program, Respondent shall ensure that a certificate/letter of completion is provided to the Board. These program hours completed pursuant to this section shall be required in addition to, and may not be counted toward, the mandatory Continuing Professional Development requirements for an active Colorado license or to meet any other licensure requirements.

22. During the period of probation, Respondent must successfully complete 20 hours of Board-approved professional continuing education ("CE") courses in the following areas: boundaries/dual-relationships, ethics, and record keeping. Respondent shall obtain Board approval of the courses prior to enrollment therein. Upon completion of a course, Respondent shall ensure that a certificate of completion is provided to the Board.

23. The hours of CE completed pursuant to this Order shall be in addition to, and may not be counted toward, the continuing professional competency requirements set forth in § 12-43-605, C.R.S.

TERMS AND CONDITIONS

24. Respondent will strictly observe the prohibitions set forth in § 12-43-222, C.R.S., and will ensure that he practices in accordance with the generally accepted standards of practice.

25. All expenses incurred or associated with any requirement necessary to fulfill the terms of this Order shall be the sole responsibility of Respondent.

26. In the event Respondent relocates at any time during the probationary period, Respondent shall notify the Boards of the change of address within 30 days of the effective date of such change.

27. Respondent is fully aware of and understands his right to receive a formal notice of hearing and charges and to have a formal disciplinary hearing, pursuant to § 12-43-224, C.R.S., and hereby waives those rights. Respondent acknowledges that this waiver constitutes a waiver of all rights to appeal in this matter.

28. This Order is entered into by Respondent voluntarily and without coercion, after an opportunity to consult with counsel and with full understanding of the legal consequences of this Order and the right to a formal hearing on all matters herein.

29. This Order shall constitute a Board Order for purposes of § 12-43-222, C.R.S., and shall have the same force and effect as an order entered after a formal disciplinary hearing pursuant to § 12-43-224, C.R.S.

30. Respondent acknowledges and agrees that any violation of this Order shall constitute a violation of a lawful Board Order and be grounds for further proceedings pursuant to the MHPA and, if proven, may constitute a basis for disciplinary action. The pendency of any disciplinary action shall not affect the

obligation of Respondent to comply with the terms of this Order, and this Order shall remain operative and in full force and effect.

31. This Order constitutes the entire agreement between Respondent and the Board. There are no other promises expressed or implied. In the event that any provision of this Order is deemed unenforceable by a court of competent jurisdiction, such provision shall be severed, and the remainder of this Order shall be given full force and effect.

32. This Order shall become effective upon (a) mailing by first-class mail to Respondent at Respondent's address of record with the Board, or (b) service by electronic means on Respondent at Respondent's electronic address of record with the Board. Respondent hereby consents to service by electronic means if Respondent has an electronic address on file with the Board.

33. This Order shall be a public record in the custody of the Board.

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AGREED TO AND ACCEPTED BY:

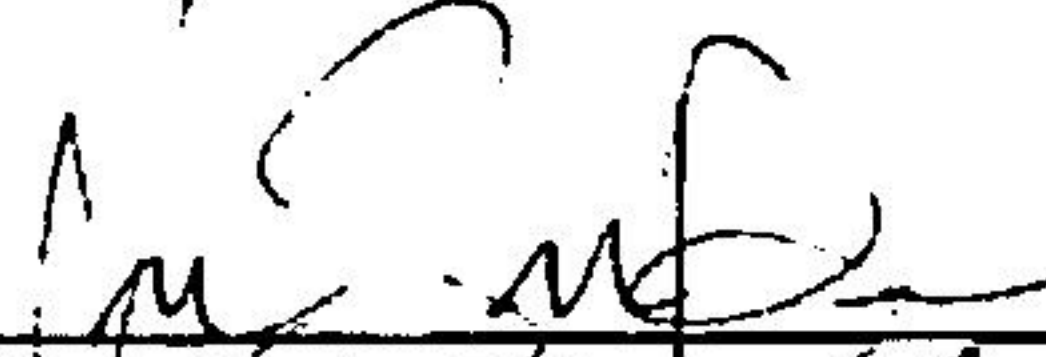
RESPONDENT



Steven J. Wolhandler, License No. LPC
4564

AGREED TO AND ORDERED BY:

**BOARD OF LICENSED
PROFESSIONAL COUNSELOR
EXAMINERS**



Ariana Busby ~~Kingston~~
Program Director

Effective this Date:

July 14, 2019